



Printing for your office?

Have a look at our MFD test for the perfect printing solution for your office needs

Wi-Fi theft

It is estimated that one third of the Americans use Wi-Fi which does not belong to them

Smart SoHo

even helps employees self-manage their activities, which is the beauty of it. As an employee, your first step is to input a few priorities or projects you are working on. The software is unobtrusive and silently tracks activities, requiring hardly any manual input once the initial priorities are entered. The application is quite intuitive as well with provision for marking time away from the computer as a break, or 'work off computer'. It has an option to set daily tasks such as checking mail. If it notices no activity on your computer for a certain period of time, or if you are farting around on sites such as Facebook, you get a pop-up which goes something like "it's awfully quiet at your end, are you still working on so and so task?"

The software is powerful enough to track typical time-wasting websites such as Facebook, Twitter and even news sites. All this info is time stamped and stored away for retrieval by an admin. Time Doctor calls them "poor time use websites" and data for these can be found in the admin panel.

At the end of the day the application sends a report consisting of hours worked, and on what tasks, to the server. Admins have the option of receiving daily or weekly reports of their employees activities. Reports can even be generated on the fly as per requirement – by employee, time period, etc – from the admin dashboard. As an added level of enforcement, Time Doctor also features taking automatic screen shots of your employees activities. In the Time Doctor desktop client, click on Screenshots. This



Time Doctor monitoring the activity of an employee



PaperCut In Action

will launch a program called "Screenshot Viewer". Here you can choose from a drop down list the employees whose screenshots you want, then choose where you want the folder created and click "download". The screenshots will then be pulled from the employee's computer and made viewable in the folder you have designated.

We implemented Time Doctor for our little team and came out with some surprising insights for ourselves. Errr not that we ever slack off or anything.

Monitor printer usage

Did you know printer misuse is one the most common forms of mischief employees indulge in? Often you'll find people taking printouts when they're not really necessary. Employees even take prints for personal use. It's common for kids to tell their parents to print out an eBook or school/

college report from office. As a small business owner you'd rather not have this additional expense and drain. PaperCut is an interesting application suite that can allow you to drastically cut down printing costs by monitoring printer usage and assigning print quotas to users. The basic solution called PaperCut Print Logger is free to use and runs as a service on individual computers, silently tracking details of printer usage such as time of print, quantity etc. Logs are available in a friendly HTML format or in an Excel format to facilitate

further data analysis. There is an advanced version with network support called PaperCut NG. A free version of PaperCut NG is made available for small offices and home users (upto five users). It will not ask for a licence as long as it detects five or less users on the network. The software needs to be installed on the PC hosting the printer or a Print Server that manages print queues. There's also a client software that needs to be installed on individual workstations. It intercepts prints orders and launches the pop ups where users are alerted about their remaining quotas. A detailed instruction manual is included in the installation bundle. You can download it from <http://www.papercut.com/download/ng/>. Once the installation is complete you can assign print quotas for different users from the convenient Web UI.

The best deterrent

Applications such as TimeDoctor and PaperCut make no effort to hide the fact that they are monitoring an employee's activity. Yet there are many apps out there that stray more towards eavesdropping than just monitoring. Although it's not illegal to monitor employees' computers by using almost any means (even keyloggers and email spying), it's not very ethical is it? The law gives you full rights to protect your intellectual property and hence implement all sorts of measures. Yet the best deterrent out there is simply telling employees that they're being monitored. If they know they're under the scanner, they will be more likely to concentrate on work-related tasks. And now, thanks to us you have the tools to back your fair warning! 